Meals & Entertainment: Nonprofit Categorization Methodology

Functional expense classification, plus tax and grant compliance notes

For a typical 501(c)(3) funded by donations and grants, the IRS's deductibility framework generally doesn't apply — that framework limits a *taxable* business's deductions, and most nonprofit activity isn't taxable income to begin with. Instead, meals and entertainment should be sorted by **function** for Form 990 and financial statement reporting: Program Services, Management & General, or Fundraising. The deductibility framework only resurfaces in the specific situations noted below.

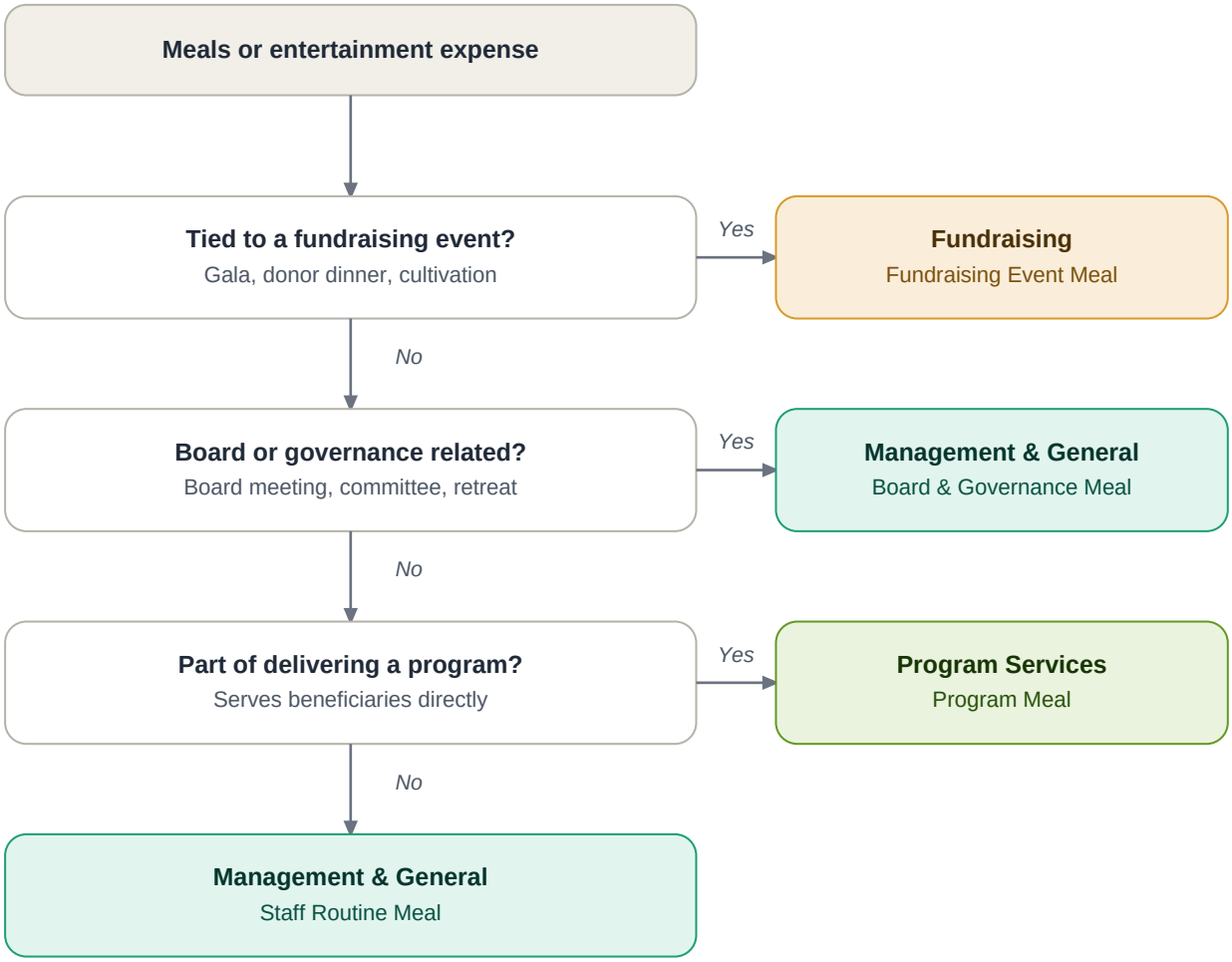
Category	Type / examples	Functional class
Program Meals	Meals provided as part of delivering a program or service to beneficiaries — e.g. meals at a client workshop, food provided during a program-related retreat, meals for participants at a training session	Program Services
Board & Governance Meals	Meals during board meetings, committee meetings, or governance retreats — e.g. dinner before a board meeting, a working lunch during a strategic planning retreat	Management & General
Staff Routine Meals	Everyday staff lunches and working meals not tied to a program or fundraising activity — e.g. the team grabbing lunch together, a working lunch during a busy stretch, or a regular team lunch delivered to the office as a perk. A stocked pantry, coffee, or snacks kept in the break room also fall here for functional reporting, but see the UBI note below	Management & General*
Fundraising Event Meals	Meals tied to cultivating or soliciting donors — e.g. a gala dinner, a donor cultivation lunch, a donor appreciation reception	Fundraising
Entertainment	Tickets, golf outings, club-related entertainment costs — e.g. tickets included in a fundraising event, a round of golf with a major donor	Classify by purpose above

*** Unrelated Business Income (UBI):** if the organization runs a trade or business unrelated to its exempt purpose, the same 50%/100%/0% limits from our general methodology guide apply when figuring the taxable income on Form 990-T for that activity. As of 2026, two things drop staff meals to 0% deductible against UBI: an employer-run cafeteria or a stocked pantry/food-drink supply (like break room snacks and coffee), and meals provided because there's a genuine business reason staff must remain available or can't leave — not simply because a meal is eaten on-site. A team lunch delivered to the office as a regular perk stays at 50% either way. This only affects costs tied to the unrelated business itself.

Federal grants: costs charged to a federal award follow the federal grant cost rules, not the IRS deductibility rules above. Entertainment costs are generally unallowable as a direct charge to a federal award regardless of business purpose, and meals tied to conferences or training have their own specific allowability requirements. Check the award's terms before charging meals or entertainment to a federal grant.

Which functional category do I use?

Use this flow to decide which functional category applies to a given meal or entertainment expense. If the cost is charged to a federal grant, confirm allowability under the grant's cost rules first.



Entertainment costs (tickets, golf, club dues) follow the same functional logic above based on their purpose — they don't get their own branch, but if federal grant funds are involved, confirm allowability separately, since entertainment is generally unallowable on federal awards.